

Object Property Mutations in Legacy Svelte

Q29

STATE (LEGACY)

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Question. How do you force a reactive update after modifying an object property in Svelte 3/4?

ANSWER. In Svelte 3 and 4, modifying a nested property on an object (e.g., `user.age = 31`) does not automatically trigger the reactivity system. Because the compiler tracks assignments at the top-level identifier to inject invalidation code, you must explicitly reassign the object to itself (`user = user`) or assign it a completely new object reference (often using the spread operator) to force the UI to render the updated state.

App.svelte

```
<script>
  let user = { name: 'Alice', age: 30 };

  function updateAge() {
    // ❌ Mutating a nested property does NOT trigger an update
    user.age = 31;

    // ✅ Legacy fix 1: Reassign the object to itself
    user = user;

    // ✅ Legacy fix 2: Reassign using the spread operator
    // user = { ...user, age: 31 };
  }
}
```

```
</script>
```

```
<button on:click={updateAge}>  
  {user.name} is {user.age} years old  
</button>
```

- ① **Summary.** Mutating an object property directly avoids detection by the compiler in Svelte 3 and 4. You must always use an explicit top-level assignment to force the UI to react to the updated state.

PROPERTY MUTATION (SILENT)

`user.age = 31`

TOP-LEVEL ASSIGNMENT (REACTIVE)

`user = user`